MJC-02: European Classical Literature

Full Marks: 100 | **Credits:** 6

Unit 1: Homer – *The Iliad*

Text: *The Iliad*, translated by E. V. Rieu, Penguin, 1985

1.1 Introduction to the Author and Text

- 1.1.1 Homer's life and literary significance
- 1.1.2 Epic tradition and the place of *The Iliad* in it

1.2 Plot and Characters

- 1.2.1 Background of the Trojan War
- 1.2.2 Major characters: Achilles, Hector, Agamemnon, Helen, etc.
- 1.2.3 Role of gods and divine intervention

1.3 Themes and Style

- 1.3.1 Heroism, fate, and glory
- 1.3.2 War and human suffering
- 1.3.3 Poetic devices and narrative style

Unit 2: Sophocles – *Oedipus the King*

Text: *Oedipus the King*, translated by Robert Fagles in *The Three Theban Plays*

2.1 Introduction to Greek Tragedy and Sophocles

- 2.1.1 Origin and features of Greek tragedy
- 2.1.2 Life and works of Sophocles

2.2 Plot Structure and Characters

- 2.2.1 Summary of the play
- 2.2.2 Character analysis: Oedipus, Jocasta, Tiresias, Creon

2.3 Themes and Techniques

- 2.3.1 Fate vs. Free Will
- 2.3.2 Tragic irony and dramatic tension
- 2.3.3 Catharsis and moral vision

Unit 3: Plato – *The Republic* (Book X)

Text: *The Republic* (Book X), translated by Desmond Lee, Penguin, 2007

3.1 Introduction to Plato and His Philosophy

- 3.1.1 Life of Plato and the Academy
- 3.1.2 Overview of *The Republic*

3.2 Key Philosophical Ideas in Book X

- 3.2.1 Theory of Imitation (Mimesis)
- 3.2.2 Art and its moral implications
- 3.2.3 The concept of the ideal state and the philosopher

Unit 4: Aristotle – *Poetics*

Text: *Poetics*, translated and introduced by Malcolm Heath, Penguin, 1996
(Prescribed Chapters: 8–17, 23, 26)

4.1 Introduction to Aristotle and Classical Literary Criticism

- 4.1.1 Aristotle's life and works
- 4.1.2 Context of *Poetics* in literary theory

4.2 Key Concepts from the Text

- 4.2.1 Definition and elements of tragedy
- 4.2.2 Plot (Mythos), Character (Ethos), and Thought (Dianoia)
- 4.2.3 Catharsis, Unity of Action, and the tragic hero

4.3 Relevance and Impact

- 4.3.1 Influence of Aristotle on later criticism
- 4.3.2 Comparative insights: Plato vs. Aristotle on art